Archaeologists May Have Found the World's Oldest Shipwreck

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Archaeologists may have found the world's oldest shipwreck, or at least, a strong candidate for the title. Based on clues from its cargo, including pottery vessels, a research team has tentatively dated the wreck to around 2700-2400 **BCE**, but much work remains and a paper is yet to be published in a **peer-reviewed** journal.

Associate Professor Hakan Öniz of Akdeniz University, Antalya, found the wreck in shallow waters off Kekova, west of Antalya in Turkey, in 2024, acting on clues from local seafarers. Earlier this year, he asked a colleague to help date some of the pottery vessels found on the wreck.

There is now nothing to see of the ship itself, owing to underwater exposure. What remains is its cargo, embedded in the rocky slope along the Kekova coast, and the ship now rests on the seabed between two islands. The team believes it likely sought refuge in calmer lee waters during a storm while traveling along the coast of southern Turkey.

Divers worked over the past four months to extract pottery from **barnacles** clinging to the rocky underwater slope. The cargo included large ceramic storage vessels, or **amphorae**, which once contained products from regions of the eastern Mediterranean.

The pots were large, egg-shaped, flat-based jars with two handles, many with a raised horizontal clay belt around the widest part. Their shape and manufacturing technique help researchers date the cargo, and by extension the ship itself, though the precise dating is still under consideration, and earlier or later dates are also possible.

If the dating holds, the discovery could transform understanding of ancient Mediterranean connections during the **Early Bronze Age**, around 4,500 years ago.

Word Treasure

amphorae -- Large clay jars used long ago to store and carry goods.
peer-reviewed -- Checked by other experts in the same field before being published.
BCE -- A way of counting years before year 1, used for ancient history.
barnacles -- Small sea animals that stick hard to rocks and other surfaces underwater.
Early Bronze Age -- A very ancient time when people first began using bronze.

Background you need

Archaeologists study things people left behind long ago, and objects found underwater can survive for a very long time.

Pottery is especially useful because its shape and the way it was made change over time, so experts can use it to judge how old a find is.

In the ancient Mediterranean, ships carried goods such as pottery between coastal places, and a wreck can show which places were connected by trade.

When only the cargo survives, researchers must piece together the story from what remains on the seabed.

Break it down

LEAD: Archaeologists may have found the world's oldest shipwreck, a strong candidate for the title.

KEY EVENT: A research team tentatively dated the wreck from its pottery cargo.

+- WHO: Associate Professor Hakan Öniz of Akdeniz University, Antalya
+- WHERE: Shallow waters off Kekova, west of Antalya in Turkey
+- WHEN: Found in 2024; pottery dated with a colleague's help earlier this year

EVIDENCE: Large egg-shaped amphorae with two handles, whose shape and manufacturing technique help date the cargo; the ship itself is gone and only cargo embedded in the rocky slope remains

OPEN QUESTION: The precise dating is still under consideration, earlier or later dates are possible, and no paper has yet been published in a peer-reviewed journal

Why it matters

If the dating holds, this wreck could rewrite what we know about how far ancient Mediterranean peoples travelled and traded around 4,500 years ago.

Test what you remember

1. What may archaeologists have found?

(A) A new island near Turkey
(B) The world's oldest shipwreck, or at least a strong candidate for the title
(C) A treasure chest full of gold coins
(D) A sunken Roman palace

2. What date range has the wreck been tentatively given?

(A) Around 4500 BCE
(B) Around 2700-2400 BCE
(C) Around 2024 CE
(D) Around 500-400 BCE

3. Who found the wreck?

(A) A colleague who dated the pottery
(B) Associate Professor Hakan Öniz of Akdeniz University
(C) Local seafarers
(D) A team of divers

4. What remains of the ship itself?

(A) Just one anchor
(B) The whole wooden hull
(C) Only a few planks
(D) Nothing; only its cargo, embedded in the rocky slope

5. What did the cargo include?

(A) Glass bottles
(B) Large ceramic storage vessels, or amphorae
(C) Gold statues
(D) Bronze weapons

6. If the dating holds, what could the discovery transform?

(A) The map of modern Turkey
(B) Understanding of ancient Mediterranean connections during the Early Bronze Age
(C) The way divers work underwater
(D) The history of the Akdeniz University

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: B 4: D 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

1. The research team: The ship likely sought refuge in calmer lee waters during a storm while travelling along the coast of southern Turkey.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):